Aliasgar Bangcola

Colonel Aliasgar Bala Bangcola (Ret.), also known by his traditional title **Sultan a Adel sa Deroyomod**, is a retired officer of the Armed Forces of the Philippines (AFP) and a respected traditional leader within the Maranao community of Mindanao. Over the course of his military career, he held command and leadership posts in several parts of Mindanao, most notably in Marawi City and Cotabato, and became known for his work bridging military institutions with local communities during a period marked by conflict between government forces and the Moro Islamic Liberation Front (MILF).

What sets Bangcola apart from many officers of his generation isn't just the medals or the rank, it's the choice he made, again and again, to sit down and talk instead of just give orders. In a region where the line between soldier and neighbor often blurred, he chose dialogue as a tool of war's end, not just its conduct, and family accounts describe at least one moment where that choice may have stopped a bloodbath before it started.

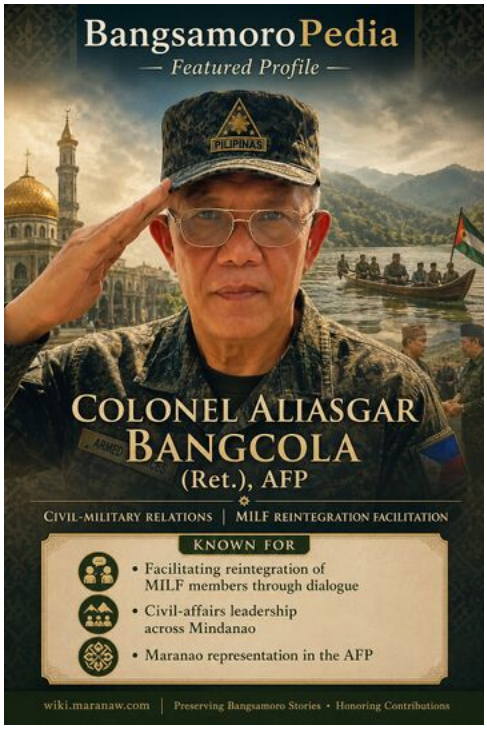
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BACKGROUND

Aliasgar Bala Bangcola was born on November 27, 1951. According to family-submitted biographical material, he is the son of Sultan Brigadier General Jimmy Bangcola and Bae Hadja Amina. His father is described by the family as a figure who shaped his early commitment to leadership, discipline, and public service. Growing up in a household carrying both military tradition and royal Maranao lineage, Bangcola developed early on a sense of duty that would carry him through decades of service, first in uniform, then in his post-retirement life as a traditional leader and community figure.

Sultan Colonel Aliasgar Bala Bangcola (Ret.)



Born

November 27, 1951

Title

Sultan a Adel sa Deroyomod

Allegiance

Republic of the Philippines

Service

Armed Forces of the Philippines (AFP)

Rank

Colonel (Ret.); commissioned 2nd Lieutenant

Unit

Task Force Tugis

Service Areas

Marawi City, Cotabato, and other provinces across Mindanao

Ethnicity

Maranao

Notability

He later assumed the traditional title of **Sultan a Adel sa Deroyomod**, a recognition tied to the Maranao sultanate system, reflecting his standing not just as a military officer but as a respected figure within the community's traditional leadership structure.

Retired AFP officer, traditional Maranao Sultan, and peace negotiator credited with facilitating the surrender of armed outlaws through dialogue rather than combat

Known For

Negotiating mass surrenders, civil-military relations, and peace-building between the AFP and former MILF members in Lanao del Sur

EDUCATION

Bangcola earned his undergraduate degree in Political Science, then went on to pursue law studies at JPI (Jamiatul Philippine Islamia), continuing his studies at the Jamiatul Philippine Al-Islamia in Marawi City, Lanao del Sur. That combination, political science grounding followed by legal and Islamic studies, gave him a working understanding of governance, law, and conflict resolution long before those skills became central to his work facilitating dialogue between the AFP and MILF. It's the kind of background that doesn't always show up on a service record, but it shaped how he approached his later assignments: less as a purely military man, more as someone who understood that lasting peace needed more than firepower.

CAREER

Bangcola's service with the AFP spanned multiple provinces and cities across Mindanao, with significant postings in Marawi City and Cotabato. Throughout his career, he held various command and leadership positions, and his responsibilities extended well past conventional military operations. He was deeply involved in civil-military relations and community development programs, areas where his legal and political science training, paired with his standing as a Maranao officer, gave him an edge that few others in the AFP could claim.

He was part of Task Force Tugis, one of the more prominent task forces operating in the Lanao provinces during his time in service.

Civil-Military and Peace-Building Work

One of the most significant chapters of his service, according to family accounts, involves an encounter in Lanao del Sur where a group of armed outlaws had barricaded themselves near a bridge. With AFP command preparing to destroy the bridge to flush them out, and Bangcola's battalion ordered to retreat ahead of the demolition, he chose a different path. Rather than allow the standoff to end in bloodshed, he reportedly went down to the outlaws himself, laid down his arms, and had his battalion do the same. What followed was a negotiation: he warned them plainly that the bridge would be destroyed regardless, and convinced them to surrender into his custody rather than risk being caught in the blast. The outlaws yielded, and the confrontation ended without a single shot fired.

Family accounts also reference reporting by Philstar connected to his role in facilitating outlaw surrenders in Lanao del Sur, including a group of 55 individuals. This specific reporting could not be independently located at the time of writing (see editorial notes).

Recognition

Across his years in service, Bangcola earned numerous medals, commendations, certificates of recognition, and awards, both from military superiors and from government and local officials. These honors reflected not just years served, but the regard he earned from people on both sides of the civilian-military divide, a rare thing for an officer working in one of the country's most historically tense regions.

CONTRIBUTIONS

Bangcola's most lasting contribution may be the relationships he helped build rather than any single operation he led. Through sustained community engagement, confidence-building measures, and a documented willingness to negotiate even at personal risk, he worked to narrow the distance between the AFP and former MILF members and other armed groups, encouraging a model of peace that depended on mutual respect rather than coercion.

This wasn't peace-building in the abstract sense. It meant showing up, sometimes literally disarming himself in front of armed men, and earning enough trust that surrender became a viable option instead of a last resort met with force. The relationships forged through those efforts are credited with contributing to longer-term peace initiatives that, in various forms, continue to shape the region today.

HISTORICAL SIGNIFICANCE

Bangcola's career is, in many ways, a window into the broader story of Maranao officers within the Philippine military, a story that doesn't get told often enough. His work demonstrated something the AFP didn't always practice in Mindanao's most difficult years: that durable peace comes not only from military superiority, but from the slower, harder work of dialogue, mutual respect, and a willingness to put down arms first.

As one of the respected Maranao officers of his generation, and later a recognized Sultan within the traditional leadership system, Bangcola helped strengthen the visibility and representation of Muslim Filipinos within the AFP's ranks, serving as something of a bridge between an institution often viewed with suspicion in Muslim Mindanao and the communities it operated in.

LEGACY

Bangcola's legacy reaches beyond medals and military citations. He's remembered as a soldier, yes, but also as a peace advocate, traditional leader, and community figure whose approach to conflict, soft where it could be, firm where it had to be, earned him the trust of people who had every reason to expect the opposite from a man in uniform. Family accounts describe him as someone who never treated bloodshed as a first option, and whose word, once given in negotiation, was never broken.

His commitment to public service didn't end with retirement. He went on to become a qualifying Maranao senatorial candidate, a continuation, in a different arena, of the same instinct toward leadership and nation-building that defined his military years. For younger officers, public servants, and members of the Bangsamoro community coming up today, his life offers a working example of what it looks like to serve in uniform, and in traditional leadership, without losing sight of the people that service is meant to protect.

SEE ALSO

- Armed Forces of the Philippines
- Moro Islamic Liberation Front
- Maranao people
- Marawi City
- Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao
- Philippine Military Academy

REFERENCES

Template:Reflist

- Philstar (referenced by family as reporting on the surrender of 55 outlaws in Lanao del Sur facilitated by Col. Bangcola; specific article title, date, and byline not provided in source material; not independently located online as of this writing)
- Biographical material submitted by Cobby Cobrah Bangcola, family representative and grandson of the subject (Facebook (https://www.facebook.com/cobbycobrah.bangcola))
- Additional info submitted by Ben Bāngcolā (https://www.facebook.com/BinAli.Bangcola)

CATEGORIES

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